

Half Full or Half Empty

The Role of Optimism in Boundary-Spanning Positions

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Previous research demonstrates the dysfunctional consequences of high levels of role stressors (role ambiguity and role conflict) in boundary-spanning positions. These consequences include higher levels of burnout and lower levels of satisfaction and performance. Although marketing researchers have investigated external mechanisms for coping with role stressors, research to date has not investigated the inherent capability of boundary spanners to cope with role stressors. This research examines optimism as an internal characteristic that facilitates coping with role stressors in boundary-spanning positions. The research findings reveal that optimists are able to anticipate and respond proactively to stressors, resulting in less burnout and higher levels of performance and satisfaction.

Keywords: *optimism; role stressors; proactive coping; job satisfaction; performance*

A pessimist sees the difficulty in every opportunity; an optimist sees the opportunity in every difficulty.

Sir Winston Churchill

Positive psychology research suggests optimism has the potential for a strong, positive influence in the workplace (Luthans 2002), particularly in the presence of role stressors. Yet few studies to date have examined the role of optimism in the marketing function (e.g., Dixon and Schertzer 2005; Rich 1999; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993). To fill this void, our research examines optimism as an internal characteristic that facilitates coping with role stressors experienced by service providers in boundary-spanning positions. Service providers often experience stress due to their boundary-spanning roles (Singh 2000; Singh and Rhoads 1991). This felt stress results from role stressors (i.e., role conflict and role ambiguity) that arise as service providers balance their obligations to the organization and to the customer (Kahn et al. 1964). Research has found that these stressful, boundary-spanning roles often lead to burnout, which in turn, lowers performance and satisfaction and increases turnover rates (Fogarty

et al. 2000). For the boundary spanner, coping with burnout is key to overcoming the adverse effects of role stressors.

Academicians have recognized that the search for effective coping mechanisms that serve to alleviate burnout tendencies is critical to the advancement of knowledge in this area (Fogarty et al. 2000). As a result, considerable research has been devoted to examining external coping mechanisms, including job design characteristics and managerial support (e.g., Singh 1993). This research suggests that when boundary-spanning employees are working in situations characterized by participation, feedback, autonomy, and managerial consideration, they are better able to cope with role stressors (e.g., Singh 1993, 1998). Despite a wealth of research focusing on external coping mechanisms, extant research fails to consider the internal characteristics of employees and how these characteristics influence their coping responses.

Individuals differ in their ability to cope with stressors (Folkman and Lazarus 1980), stemming largely from the

Authors' Note: The authors would like to thank the editor and three anonymous reviewers for their comments on earlier versions of this article.

different coping strategies employed when individuals encounter stressors. Individuals may employ active, problem-focused coping strategies or passive, emotion-focused coping strategies. Problem-focused coping aims to eliminate or circumvent the source of adversity, whereas emotion-focused coping aims to avoid the emotional distress associated with the source of adversity (Scheier and Carver 1985; Strutton and Lumpkin 1993). The type of coping strategies employed is determined in large part by the individual's level of optimism (Nes and Segerstrom 2006; Scheier and Carver 1985). Additionally, the individual's level of optimism influences the appraisal of stressors (Chang 1998) and the development of social support structures (Brisette, Scheier, and Carver 2002)—both of which assist in coping with stressors. The exact mechanisms that enable optimists to deal more effectively with stressors are outside the scope of this research. Instead, we aim to examine the role of optimism in boundary-spanning positions.

Our research augments Singh and his colleagues' research by identifying an internal characteristic that may facilitate coping with role stressors. Our research also examines whether optimism mediates or predicts the stressor-outcome relationship. Extant research has found support for the mediating effects of optimism on the stressor-outcome relationship (Chang 1998). Yet more recent research on proactive coping suggests optimism may serve as an antecedent to the stressor-outcome relationship (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Therefore, a second contribution of this research is to clarify the role of optimism in the stressor-outcome relationship in boundary-spanning positions.

The article is organized as follows. First, we define role stressors and discuss their impact on boundary-spanning positions. Then, drawing on optimism research and role theory (Kahn et al. 1964), we present two competing models that examine the interrelationships among stressors, burnout, optimism, and job outcomes. Next, we present the results of our empirical analyses examining these interrelationships. Finally, we conclude with managerial implications and future research directions.

Conceptual Framework

Drawing on optimism and role theory research (Kahn et al. 1964), we develop two competing models for coping with role stressors in boundary-spanning positions (see Figures 1 and 2). In the first model, we posit optimism will facilitate coping with role stressors, which in turn, will lead to lower levels of burnout and higher satisfaction and

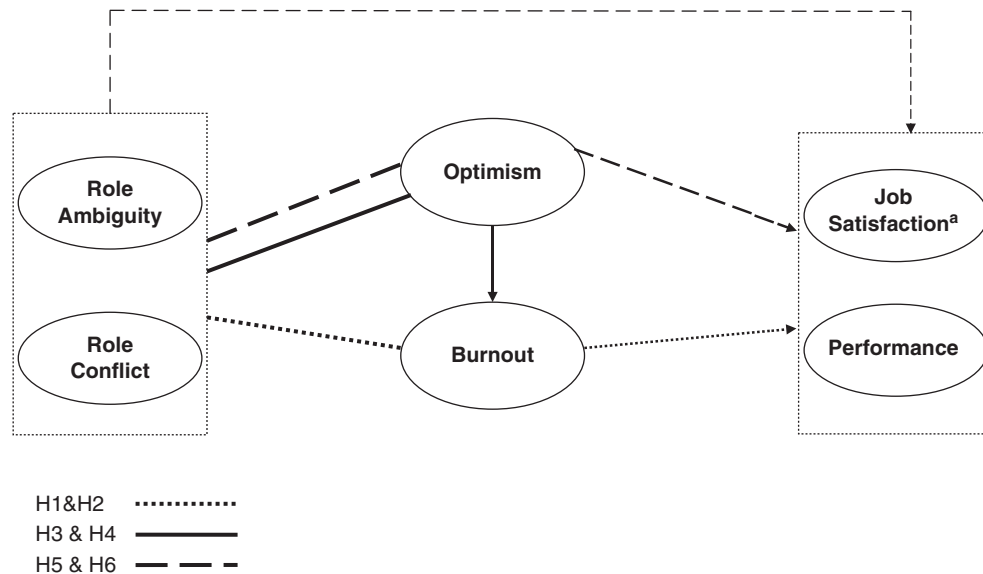
performance in boundary-spanning positions. In the competing model, we posit optimism will enable boundary spanners to anticipate and respond proactively to stressors before they occur, which will alleviate burnout and increase job outcomes. The competing hypotheses are formalized in the subsequent sections.

Role Stress in Boundary-Spanning Positions

Boundary spanners are employees who operate on the periphery of the organization, such as service providers or salespeople (Singh and Rhoads 1991). They often experience high levels of role stress (Singh 2000) or pressure resulting from expectations placed on them by different role players (Nygaard and Dahlstrom 2002). Research in marketing has found that boundary spanners are particularly susceptible to two types of role stressors—role conflict and role ambiguity (Behrman and Perreault 1984; Churchill, Ford, and Walker 1976; Fry et al. 1986; Singh 1993; Singh, Verbeke, and Rhoads 1996). Role conflict refers to “the degree of incongruity or incompatibility of expectations associated with the role” (House and Rizzo 1972, p. 475). Hence, role conflict occurs when two different members of an employee's role set (e.g., managers and customers) have conflicting demands (Singh 1998). Role ambiguity, in contrast, refers to “lack of clarity and predictability of the outcomes of one's behavior” (House and Rizzo 1972, p. 475). According to Kahn et al. (1964), role ambiguity is a function of the discrepancy between the information available and the information needed for adequate performance.

According to role theory (Kahn et al. 1964), high levels of role conflict and/or role ambiguity produce stress. The felt stress will result in dissatisfaction, anxiety, and distorted views of reality—all of which impede performance and satisfaction—unless the stress can be minimized through effective coping mechanisms (House and Rizzo 1972). A considerable body of research has examined the influence of role stressors on performance and satisfaction (e.g., Bagozzi 1978; Behrman and Perreault 1984; Donnelly and Ivancevich 1975; Hampton, Dubinsky, and Skinner 1986; Senatra 1980; Singh 1993, 1998, 2000; Singh and Rhoads 1991; Singh, Verbeke, and Rhoads 1996). Although mixed findings have been reported (Dubinsky and Mattson 1979; Fogarty et al. 2000; Nygaard and Dahlstrom 2002; Senatra 1980), there is a generally accepted view that role stressors have significant dysfunctional effects on job outcomes (Singh 1998). This view is consistently supported by meta-analytic studies of role stressors (e.g., Fisher and Giltelson 1983; Jackson and Schuler 1985; Tubre and Collins 2000).

Figure 1
Optimism as a Mediator Model



Note: The paths between role stressors and the outcome variables are dashed because the direct effects are expected to be partially mediated by optimism and burnout. H = hypothesis.

a. Extant theoretical and empirical research supports a positive relationship between job satisfaction and performance (e.g., Babakus et al. 1996; Petty, McGee, and Cavender 1984; Singh 1993; Williams and Livingstone 1994). Testing the relationship between these variables is outside the scope of this research. Consistent with extant research, however, these variables are correlated in the structural model.

More recent research identifies burnout as a key mediator between stressors and outcomes (Fogarty et al. 2000; Singh, Goolsby, and Rhoads 1994). Burnout is described as an affective response to “continuous and prolonged exposure to stress, particularly work-related stress” (Melamed et al. 2006, p. 327). Burnout occurs when “certain valued resources are lost, are inadequate to meet demands, or do not yield anticipated returns” (Lee and Ashforth 1996, p. 123). The loss (or overwhelming) of resources has a deleterious effect on many outcomes, including behavioral coping response, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment (see Lee and Ashforth 1990). Hence, we anticipate,

Hypothesis 1: Burnout will partially mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Hypothesis 2: Burnout will partially mediate the relationship between role conflict and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

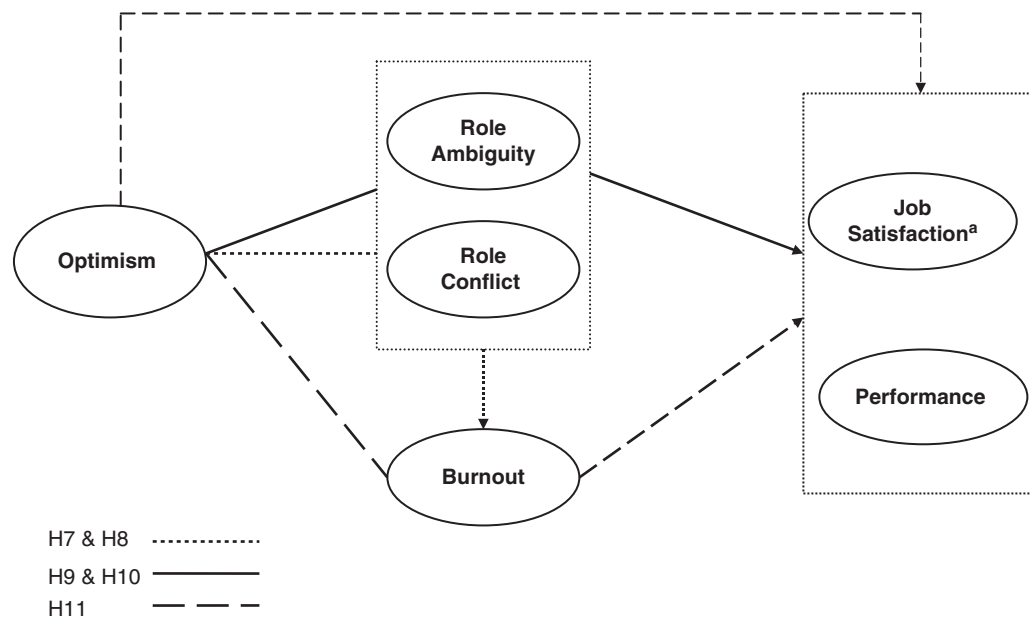
Optimism as a Mediator

Dispositional optimism, defined as the general expectation of positive or favorable outcomes in life’s events (Chang 2001; Gillham et al. 2001; Scheier and Carver

1985), is expected to alleviate resource loss and facilitate coping with role stressors. Extant research shows that optimists are “psychologically and physically better adjusted than their pessimistic counterparts” (Chang 1998, p. 1109). Moreover, they perform better when tasks are challenging and require persistence to overcome obstacles (Schulman 1999; Seligman 1998). Seligman (1998), for example, found that optimistic insurance sales agents sold 37% more insurance on average in their first 2 years of work than pessimistic agents. Similarly, Rich (1999) found that optimistic salespeople achieved higher levels of in-role performance. More recently, Dixon and Schertzer (2005) found that optimistic salespeople plan to work harder following failed sales calls than their pessimistic counterparts.

The beneficial effects of optimism extend to satisfaction. Scheier et al. (1989) found that optimists reported higher levels of satisfaction than pessimists after undergoing heart surgery. In a different setting, optimistic students reported higher overall quality of life, as compared to their pessimistic counterparts (Harju and Bolen 1998). A common thesis in this research is that optimistic individuals are more satisfied, achieve more, and perform better in stressful situations (e.g., Scheier and Carver 1985; Scheier et al. 1989; Seligman 1998;

Figure 2
Optimism as an Antecedent Model



Note: The paths between optimism and the outcome variables are dashed because the direct effects are expected to be partially mediated by role stressors and burnout. H = hypothesis.

a. Extant theoretical and empirical research supports a positive relationship between job satisfaction and performance (e.g., Babakus et al. 1996; Petty, McGee, and Cavender 1984; Singh 1993; Williams and Livingstone 1994). Testing the relationship between these variables is outside the scope of this research. Consistent with extant research, however, these variables are correlated in the structural model.

Strutton and Lumpkin 1993). This research suggests that optimism will partially mediate the positive relationship between the role stressors and burnout and the negative relationship between role stressors and job outcomes.

Mediation occurs when a particular variable accounts for the relationship between the predictor and criterion variables (Baron and Kenny 1986). According to Woodworth (1928), external stimuli, such as role ambiguity and role conflict, can only influence an individual's responses through the "internal workings" of the individual. Research has demonstrated that the internal workings of optimistic individuals differ from those of pessimistic individuals (Chang 1998; Nes and Segerstrom 2006; Scheier and Carver 1985), and these differences enable optimists to manage stressors more effectively. Specifically, research has identified differences in cognitive appraisals, coping strategies, and support systems as possible explanations for how optimists adjust better than pessimists to stressors or adversity.

Appraisals, which are cognitive interpretations one has regarding a potential stressor (Lazarus and Folkman 1984), differ for optimists and pessimists. In varying levels of stressful situations, optimistic individuals tend

to report lower levels of stress (Nes and Segerstrom 2006), suggesting optimists differ in their primary appraisals of stressors. Tuten and Neidermeyer (2004) similarly found that optimistic call center employees perceive lower levels of stress and conflict than their pessimistic counterparts. Chang (1998) found that optimists and pessimists also differ in their secondary appraisals of stressors, with optimists being more likely to contemplate their resources or options for dealing effectively with stressors. These differences in primary and secondary appraisals are expected to alleviate burnout associated with role stressors. Specifically, perceiving stressors as less threatening (primary appraisals) and contemplating the resources and skills needed to alleviate the stressor (secondary appraisals) will minimize prolonged exposure to felt stress and thus minimize burnout.

Optimistic individuals are also more likely to use active coping strategies aimed at resolving the source of adversity (Nes and Segerstrom 2006; Scheier and Carver 1985). Strutton and Lumpkin (1993) found that optimistic salespeople used more problem-focused coping strategies that aim to eliminate or circumvent the source

of adversity. Pessimistic salespeople, in contrast, used more emotion-focused coping strategies with the goal of reducing the emotional consequences associated with the adversity encountered. More recent research found that optimistic individuals use various coping strategies, and they adjust their coping strategies to resolve the specific stressors being faced (Nes and Segerstrom 2006). Pessimists, in contrast, tended to rely on avoidance coping strategies (i.e., avoiding or ignoring the stressor) (Nes and Segerstrom 2006). These findings suggest optimists will cope more effectively with stressors, which again will minimize prolonged exposure to felt stress and consequently minimize burnout.

Finally, research suggests optimists develop more extensive and supportive social networks that enable them to deal more effectively with stressors (Brisette, Scheier, and Carver 2002). A social support network enables individuals to manage stressors by providing information germane to the stressors, providing tangible aid or assistance in dealing with the stressors, and/or providing emotional support (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Optimists report greater levels of social support in general (Brisette, Scheier, and Carver 2002; Park and Folkman 1997) and greater increases in social support in stressful situations (Dougall et al. 2001). Scheier, Weintraub, and Carver (1986) found that optimists are more likely than pessimists to seek social support when needed.¹ High levels of support from managers and coworkers have been associated with lower levels of felt stress and depression (El-Bassel et al. 1998). Hence, by capitalizing on their social support structures, optimists are less likely to experience felt stress for prolonged periods of time and thus are less likely to experience burnout than pessimists.

In sum, optimism may act as a partial mediator of the stressor-burnout relationship by minimizing felt stress emanating from role stressors through primary appraisals (Tuten and Neidermeyer 2004), secondary appraisals (Chang 1998), coping strategies (Nes and Segerstrom 2006), or social support structures (Brisette, Scheier, and Carver 2002). Therefore, we posit,

Hypothesis 3: Optimism will partially mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and burnout.

Hypothesis 4: Optimism will partially mediate the relationship between role conflict and burnout.

Optimism is also expected to partially mediate the relationship between role stressors and job outcomes through its effect on cognitive appraisals, coping strategies, and social support structures. Appraisals have direct effects on adjustment to stressors (Chang 1998).

As mentioned, optimists differ from pessimists in their primary appraisals of stressors (Tuten and Neidermeyer 2004), with optimists perceiving stressors as less threatening than pessimists. The level of perceived threat influences the reactions, with a lower level of perceived threat facilitating action to reduce or minimize the threat and a higher level of perceived threat impeding action (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Due to their tendency to perceive stressors as less threatening, optimists are expected to spring into action once a stressor is perceived. Supporting this contention, Chang (1998) finds that optimists are more likely to contemplate their options for dealing with stressors than pessimists.

Moreover, Nes and Segerstrom (2006, p. 248) find the optimists are more likely to use approach coping strategies that aim to “eliminate, reduce or manage stressors or their emotional consequences.” Pessimists, in contrast, are more likely to use avoidance coping strategies that aim to “avoid, ignore or withdraw from stressors or their emotional consequences” (Nes and Segerstrom 2006, p. 248). By approaching and managing role stressors that are endemic in their boundary-spanning positions (versus avoiding and withdrawing from stressors), optimists are expected to achieve higher levels of performance and be more satisfied with their jobs than pessimists.

Optimistic boundary spanners may also achieve a high level of job outcomes by drawing on their social support structure. As mentioned, social support networks may provide tangible assistance in managing or eliminating stressors (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997), which in turn, will enable optimistic boundary spanners to better perform their duties and maintain higher levels of job satisfaction than their pessimistic counterparts (Singh 1998; Singh and Rhoads 1991). Singh (1993) demonstrates the beneficial effects of social support in managing role stressors in particular. Specifically, he found that managerial consideration, defined as “the degree to which a boss creates a facilitative climate of psychological support, mutual trust, friendliness, and helpfulness,” reduces role ambiguity (Singh 1993, p. 14). In sum, optimistic individuals have more resources and skills available to manage or eliminate stressors. Therefore, a high level of optimism is expected to partially mediate the stressor-outcome relationship. Specifically, we anticipate,

Hypothesis 5: Optimism will partially mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Hypothesis 6: Optimism will partially mediate the relationship between role conflict and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Competing Model—Optimism as an Antecedent

The competing model acknowledges that coping may occur “in anticipation of upcoming demands” (Schwarzer 2000, p. 342). Although most research has focused on how individuals react to stressors, other research examines how people anticipate and respond proactively to minimize or eliminate stressors before they develop (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997; Schwarzer 2000). Both Aspinwall and Taylor (1997) and Schwarzer (2000) identify optimism as an important individual difference variable that facilitates the use of more proactive responses to stressors. Hence, optimism may act as an antecedent as opposed to a mediator of the stressor-outcome relationship (see Figure 2).²

Proactive coping is defined as “efforts undertaken in advance of a potentially stressful event to prevent it or to modify its form before it occurs” (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997, p. 417). These efforts occur temporally prior to coping, and they involve the accumulation of resources and skills that are not aimed at a specific stressor but at stressors in general (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Aspinwall and Taylor (1997) identified five stages of proactive coping: (a) resource accumulation, which is the building up of resources and skills in advance of any specific stressor; (b) recognition of potential stressors; (c) appraisals of emerging stressors; (d) initial coping efforts or the activities undertaken that seem likely to prevent or at least minimize the potential stressor; and (e) elicitation and use of feedback.

Optimism provides beneficial effects at each stage. Schwarzer (2000) argues an optimistic belief that one can cope effectively with potential stressors is needed to plan and initiate the preventive actions that are needed to accumulate resources in anticipation of these stressors. Such resources include social bonds, wealth, and planning and organizational skills, among other individual skills (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Optimism may also facilitate the detection of potential stressors, since it heightens attention to negative information (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). As for appraisal of emerging stressors, Aspinwall and Taylor (1997) argue that optimists appraise stressful events as less threatening, and this in turn, facilitates proactive efforts toward the stressors. A high level of perceived threat, in contrast, is likely to impede action. Optimists may employ more appropriate initial coping efforts, as they are more capable of recognizing the contingencies that influence which strategies are most effective in minimizing or eliminating these stressors before they occur. Finally, optimists are more capable of using feedback and moderating their coping efforts as needed to match the characteristics of the potential stressors (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997).

In sum, optimism is expected to facilitate the use of proactive efforts to prevent or minimize potential stressors before they occur. In addition, these proactive efforts are expected to minimize the degree of stress experienced, preserve coping resources by averting or minimizing the stressor in its early stages, and provide a broader range of options for dealing with the stressor (as these options may be constrained after the stressor has occurred). All of these efforts are expected to minimize burnout and facilitate job outcomes (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Therefore, we expect,

Hypothesis 7: Role ambiguity will partially mediate the relationship between optimism and burnout.

Hypothesis 8: Role conflict will partially mediate the relationship between optimism and burnout.

Hypothesis 9: Role ambiguity will partially mediate the relationship between optimism and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Hypothesis 10: Role conflict will partially mediate the relationship between optimism and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Hypothesis 11: Burnout will partially mediate the relationship between optimism and (a) job satisfaction and (b) performance.

Research Design

Sample

The sample consisted of customer service representatives from a medium-sized, multifaceted service organization in the Midwestern United States. We selected a predominantly service-oriented organization, as the boundary-spanning nature of the participants' positions increased the likelihood that role stressors (ambiguity and conflict) would be observed. In addition, the organization was in the middle of impending administrative change, which was expected to exacerbate the anticipation of role stressors for the boundary-spanning employees.

Data collection was conducted through an online survey posted on the organization's intranet. Employees were e-mailed the link to the survey and were assured that their responses would be confidential. Steps were taken to ensure that employees did not complete the survey more than once, and employees did not receive incentives for completing the survey. In all, 220 customer service representatives responded to the online survey. Responses from 11 respondents were incomplete and deemed unusable, resulting in a final sample size of 209 and a response rate of 52%. About 50% of the respondents were male, and the mean age category was

30 to 34 years. Approximately 76% of the respondents held a bachelor's degree or higher, and the average income of the respondents was between \$35,000 and \$44,000 annually. On average, the respondents had been employed with the company between 2 and 4 years. The organization confirmed that this was an adequate representation of its customer service representatives.

Measures

With the exception of performance, variables in the research model were measured using existing scales that have demonstrated acceptable psychometric properties. All surveys were self-report measures. *Optimism* was measured using Scheier and Carver's (1985) Life Orientation Test. This scale assesses respondents' generalized expectation that positive or good things will happen. The scale items are presented in Table 1. Responses were obtained on a five-point, Likert scale (strongly disagree-strongly agree). Cronbach's alpha for the five-item scale was .751.

Role ambiguity was conceptualized as the perceived discrepancy between information available and the information needed to perform adequately, and *role conflict* was conceptualized as the perceived conflicting demands placed upon the employee. The measures for role ambiguity and role conflict were drawn from Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman (1970). Responses were obtained on a 7-point Likert scale (*very false-very true*). Cronbach's alpha was .766 for the four-item role ambiguity scale and .801 for the five-item role conflict scale.

Burnout consists of three dimensions: (a) emotional exhaustion or the feeling of depleted emotional resources, (b) depersonalization or negative excessively detached responses to other people at work, and (c) lack of personal accomplishment (Lee and Ashforth 1990; Melamed et al. 2006). Three-item scales drawn from Maslach and Jackson (1981) were used to measure each dimension. Responses were obtained on a 7-point Likert scale (*very false-very true*). Cronbach's alpha was .827, .690, and .564 for emotional exhaustion, depersonalization, and personal accomplishment, respectively, and .801 for the composite burnout measure.

Job satisfaction was measured using the Cammann et al. (1983) Job Satisfaction Scale. Cronbach's alpha was .788 for the three-item Likert scale (*strongly disagree-strongly agree*). Finally, *performance* was assessed using two self-reported items. One item assessed the respondent's perceived overall service quality, and the other item assessed the respondent's perceived overall job performance. Responses were obtained on a 7-point Likert

scale (*extremely low-extremely high*). Pearson's correlation between the items was .54.

Measure Validation Procedures

Scale purification followed the procedures outlined by Churchill (1979) and Anderson and Gerbing (1988). Confirmatory factor analysis was conducted on each scale using AMOS 7. Item loadings, modification indices, and standardized residuals for all items were scrutinized. Low loading and cross-loading items were deleted from the scales. Upon purification, reliability for all scales exceeded 0.7, and all items loaded significantly ($p < .001$), demonstrating reliability and convergent validity for each construct.

Discriminant validity was assessed using Fornell and Larcker's (1981) method. As Table 2 demonstrates, discriminant validity is established for all the measures except for emotional exhaustion and satisfaction and for personal accomplishment and the following variables: role ambiguity, emotional exhaustion, satisfaction, and performance. Hence, a chi-square difference test (Bagozzi and Phillips 1982) was conducted to further assess discriminant validity of these pairs of constructs. The significant chi-square difference tests indicate that the traits are not perfectly correlated for each pair examined with the exception of emotional exhaustion and personalization. We maintained the three-factor structure for burnout, nonetheless, to be consistent with extant research. The psychometric properties of the purified scales are included in Table 1.

Results

We employed Anderson and Gerbing's (1988) recommended procedure for testing the overall measurement model, which is identical for the competing models. An eight-factor, correlated model was estimated (Anderson and Gerbing 1988; Kline 2005). This model achieved an acceptable fit: $\chi^2(349) = 480.07$ ($p < .01$), comparative fit index (CFI) = .935. The goodness of fit index (GFI) (.870) and root mean square error of approximation (.042) further demonstrated that the measurement model achieves an acceptable fit (Browne & Cudeck 1993; Kline 2005). Given acceptable fit in the measurement model, the structural models were estimated using AMOS 7 to test the hypotheses.

Optimism as a Mediator

Table 3 presents the means, standard deviations, and correlations among the constructs, and Table 4 presents

Table 1
Measurement Models of Purified Scales

Construct/Items	Number of Items	Alpha α	CFI	GFI	AGFI	RMSEA
Optimism (Scheier and Carver 1985)	5	.751	.977	.977	.931	.081
In uncertain times, I usually expect the best.						
I always look on the bright side of things.						
I hardly ever expect things to go my way. ^a						
Things never work out the way I want them to. ^a						
I rarely count on good things happening to me. ^a						
Role ambiguity (Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970)	4	.766	.993	.991	.957	.061
I feel certain about how much authority. ^a						
I have clear, planned goals and objectives for my job. ^a						
I know what my responsibilities are. ^a						
I know exactly what is expected of me. ^a						
Role conflict (Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970)	5	.801	.983	.978	.948	.054
I have to do things that should be done differently.						
I receive an assignment without the manpower to complete it.						
I have to buck a rule of policy in order to carry out an assignment.						
I receive incompatible requests from two or more people.						
I do things that are apt to be accepted by one person and not accepted by others.						
Burnout (Maslach & Jackson 1981)	9	.801	.995	.974	.952	.021
I feel fatigued when I get up in the morning and have to face another day on the job.						
I feel burned out from my work.						
I feel frustrated by my job.						
I feel very energetic. ^a						
I can easily create a relaxed atmosphere with my recipients. ^a						
I feel exhilarated after working closely with my recipients. ^a						
I feel I treat some recipients as if they were impersonal "objects."						
I don't really care what happens to some recipients.						
I feel recipients blame me for some of their problems.						
Job satisfaction (Cammann et al. 1983)	3	.788	—	—	—	—
All in all, I'm satisfied with my job.						
In general, I like working for my company.						
In general, I do not like my job. ^a						
Performance	2	.540 ^b	—	—	—	—
I would rate my overall service quality as:						
I would rate my overall job performance as:						

Note: *df* = degrees of freedom; AGFI = adjusted goodness of fit index; CFI = comparative fit index; GFI = goodness of fit index; RMSEA = root mean square error of approximation.

a. Reverse-scored item.

b. Pearson correlation.

the results of the optimism mediator structural model. The fit indices indicate the model fits the data well: $\chi^2(360) = 545.46$ ($p < .01$), CFI = .908. The estimated model explains 86.3% of the variance in job satisfaction and 14.1% of the variance in performance. The fit indices suggest the proposed model represents the data acceptably and that the proposed model provides a basis for examining the hypotheses.

We employed Iacobucci, Saldanha, and Deng's (2007) method for testing mediation in structural equation modeling, as this method results in lower standard errors and

a greater likelihood of detecting mediation than Baron and Kenny's (1986) method. Specifically, we estimated one structural model in which the direct and indirect paths were fit simultaneously. Then, we conducted Sobel (1982) tests using p values less than or equal to .10 to examine the mediation hypotheses. Hypothesis 1a, which posits that burnout will mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and job satisfaction ($Z = -3.453$, $p < .001$), is supported. Burnout does not significantly mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and performance; thus, Hypothesis 1b is not supported.

Table 2
Discriminant Validity Tests: Average Variance Extracted and Squared Factor Correlations

	AVE ^a	Optimism	Role Ambiguity	Role Conflict	EE	PA	DP	Job Satisfaction
Optimism	.444	—						
Role ambiguity	.462	.084						
Role conflict	.406	.058	.130					
Emotional exhaustion (EE)	.609	.152	.260	.314				
Personal accomplishment (PA)	.307	.240	.360 ^b	.123	.410			
Depersonalization (DP)	.427	.048	.194	.212	.348	.292		
Job satisfaction	.589	.048	.325	.084	.672 ^b	.325 ^b	.270	
Performance	.573	.096	.123	.048	.020	.348 ^b	.109	.063

a. Discriminant validity is established when the average variance extracted (AVE) exceeds the squared factor correlation (Fornell and Larcker 1981).

b. Discriminant validity was further assessed and established using Bagozzi and Phillips's (1982) method.

Table 3
Means, Standard Deviations, Pearson Correlations (Bottom), and Covariances (Top)

	Mean	Standard Deviation	Optimism	Role Ambiguity	Role Conflict	Burnout	Job Satisfaction	Performance
Optimism	2.15	0.63	0.398 1.000	−0.192	−0.127	−0.237	0.149	0.101
Role ambiguity	4.88	1.29	−0.236	1.670 1.000	0.500	0.688	−0.774	−0.222
Role conflict	4.06	1.36	−0.147	0.284	1.854 1.000	0.684	−0.406	−0.139
Burnout	4.92	1.12	−0.336	0.476	0.449	1.251 1.000	−0.945	−0.213
Job satisfaction	2.73	1.31	0.180	−0.458	−0.228	−0.646	1.713 1.000	0.194 0.489
Performance	1.83	0.70	0.230	−0.245	−0.146	−0.272	0.212	1.000

Hypothesis 2a, which posits that burnout will mediate the relationship between role conflict and job satisfaction is supported ($Z = -3.604$, $p < .001$). Burnout does not significantly mediate the relationship between role conflict and performance; therefore, Hypothesis 2b is not supported.

Sobel (1982) tests further indicate that optimism significantly mediates the relationship between role ambiguity and burnout ($Z = 1.804$, $p < .10$), thus providing support for Hypothesis 3. Optimism does not mediate the relationship between role conflict and burnout, providing no support for Hypothesis 4. Hypothesis 5a, which posits that optimism will mediate the relationship between role ambiguity and job satisfaction, is supported ($Z = 1.681$, $p < .10$). Optimism also significantly mediates the relationship between role ambiguity and performance, providing support for Hypothesis 5b ($Z = -1.626$, $p = .10$). No support was found for Hypothesis 6, which posits optimism mediates the relationship between role conflict and job outcomes (job satisfaction and performance). Overall, support was found for optimism as a mediator

between role ambiguity and burnout, role ambiguity and job satisfaction, and role ambiguity and performance. These findings are further discussed in the discussion section.

Competing Model—Optimism as an Antecedent

Table 5 presents the results of the competing structural model. The fit indices indicate the model fits the data well: $\chi^2(360) = 540.25$ ($p < .01$), CFI = .911. The estimated model explains 86.4% of the variance in job satisfaction and 14.9% of the variance in performance. The fit indices suggest the proposed model provides a good approximation of the data and that the model provides a basis for examining the hypotheses.

Sobel (1982) tests indicate that role ambiguity mediates the relationship between optimism and burnout ($Z = -2.372$, $p < .05$), thus providing support for Hypothesis 7. Hypothesis 8, which posits that role conflict mediates the relationship between optimism and burnout, is also supported ($Z = -2.223$, $p < .05$). Mixed results were found for

Table 4
Estimated Parameters for the Mediator Structural Model and Sobel Tests

Independent Variables	Optimism γ	Burnout γ	Job Satisfaction β	Performance β
Role ambiguity	-.110 <i>-2.46**</i>	.624 <i>4.45***</i>	-.075 <i>-.467</i>	-.220 <i>-2.34**</i>
Role conflict	-.071 <i>-1.87*</i>	.609 <i>4.78***</i>	.488 <i>2.99***</i>	-.096 <i>-1.14</i>
Optimism		-.807 <i>-2.67***</i>	-.725 <i>-2.32**</i>	.403 <i>2.18**</i>
Burnout			-1.10 <i>-5.46***</i>	.023 <i>.278</i>
Sobel Tests (Z)				
Hypothesis	Predictor	Mediator	Outcome	Z
H1a	Role ambiguity	Burnout	Job satisfaction	-3.453***
H1b	Role ambiguity	Burnout	Performance	0.277
H2a	Role conflict	Burnout	Job satisfaction	-3.604***
H2b	Role conflict	Burnout	Performance	0.277
H3	Role ambiguity	Optimism	Burnout	1.804*
H4	Role conflict	Optimism	Burnout	1.531
H5a	Role ambiguity	Optimism	Job satisfaction	1.681*
H5b	Role ambiguity	Optimism	Performance	-1.626*
H6a	Role conflict	Optimism	Job satisfaction	1.454
H6b	Role conflict	Optimism	Performance	-1.418

Note: The Sobel tests examine whether optimism and burnout mediate the relationships presented. t-values are italicized.

* $p \leq .10$. ** $p \leq .05$. *** $p \leq .01$.

Hypothesis 9. While role ambiguity did not mediate the relationship between optimism and job satisfaction (Hypothesis 9a), support was found for Hypothesis 9b, which posits that role ambiguity mediates the relationship between optimism and performance ($Z = 1.794$, $p < .10$). Hypothesis 10a, which posits that role conflict mediates the relationship between optimism and job satisfaction, is supported ($Z = -1.930$, $p = .05$). No support was found for Hypothesis 10b, which posits that role conflict mediates the relationship between optimism and performance. Mixed results were found for Hypothesis 11. While burnout did not mediate the relationship between optimism and performance (Hypothesis 11b), support was found for Hypothesis 11a, which posits that burnout mediates the relationship between optimism and job satisfaction ($Z = 2.309$, $p < .05$). These findings are discussed in the discussion section.

Comparison of Competing Models

We tested two competing models—one that argues optimists react more effectively to stressors and one that argues optimists respond proactively to minimize or prevent stressors before they occur. We used Akaike's information criterion (AIC) to compare the nonnested models, with lower values indicating better fit (Kaplan 2000). The AIC for

optimism as a mediator model is 695.45, whereas the AIC for the optimism as an antecedent model is 690.25. This suggests that modeling optimism as an antecedent fits the data better than modeling optimism as a mediator.

Discussion

The results of our research reveal interesting findings worthy of discussion as well as several useful managerial implications. The findings in both models provide support for the importance of optimism as an internal characteristic that facilitates coping with role stressors. Our findings of partial support for both models may appear to be somewhat contradictory. A possible explanation for these findings is that optimistic employees use various coping mechanisms at a variety of levels and points in time when dealing with stressors. Hence, it is likely that the optimistic employees proactively respond in anticipation of future stressors (Hypothesis 7–Hypothesis 11) and react accordingly once stressors are encountered (Hypothesis 1–Hypothesis 6). Extant research acknowledges that coping occurs temporally prior to and after stressors are encountered (Lazarus 1975; Schwarzer 2000). For the current sample of employees, the company environment was in flux, with both existing and upcoming stressors. In considering the state of the

Table 5
Estimated Parameters for the Antecedent Structural Model and Sobel Tests

Independent Variables	Role Ambiguity γ	Role Conflict γ	Burnout γ	Job Satisfaction γ	Performance γ
Optimism	-.682 -2.83***	-.596 -2.53**	-.773 -2.55**	-.713 -2.28**	.395 2.12**
Role ambiguity			.618 4.37***	-.085 -0.53	-.218 -2.31**
Role conflict			.604 4.68***	.488 2.99***	-.092 -1.08
Burnout				-1.097 -5.50***	.022 0.27
Sobel Tests (Z)					
Hypothesis	Predictor	Mediator	Outcome	Z	
H7	Optimism	Role ambiguity	Burnout	-2.372**	
H8	Optimism	Role conflict	Burnout	-2.223**	
H9a	Optimism	Role ambiguity	Job satisfaction	0.522	
H9b	Optimism	Role ambiguity	Performance	1.794*	
H10a	Optimism	Role conflict	Job satisfaction	-1.930**	
H10b	Optimism	Role conflict	Performance	0.995	
H11a	Optimism	Burnout	Job satisfaction	2.309**	
H11b	Optimism	Burnout	Performance	-0.264	

Note: The Sobel tests examine whether role ambiguity, role conflict and burnout mediate the relationship present. t-values are italicized.

* $p \leq .10$. ** $p \leq .05$. *** $p \leq .01$.

organization, the explanations offered seem reasonable. Uncertainty in the organizational structure and resulting job insecurity could lead optimists to use different levels of coping throughout the duration of this organizational change.

Even though support is found for both models, the results suggest optimism as an antecedent model fits the data better. This suggests that optimists can more easily anticipate stressors and put mechanisms in place to deal with those stressors prior to their occurrence, making it less likely that they will suffer from burnout resulting from those stressors. The proactive coping literature supports this line of reasoning, as optimistic individuals are more likely to detect potential stressors and contemplate the resources they have for dealing with those stressors. They are also more likely to build up and develop the resources needed to cope with potential stressors in general. Finally, optimists may respond with more appropriate initial coping efforts that can prevent or minimize the effects of stressors prior to their occurrence (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). This proactive coping perspective has been largely ignored in the marketing literature and is deserving of additional research attention.

Managerial Implications

There are several managerial implications arising from our study. Our results clearly suggest that optimistic

employees will experience lower levels of role stressors, which in turn, will lead to more favorable job outcomes. One fairly straightforward implication is to consider the trait of optimism in the recruitment and selection process. Beyond this, it is also possible to nurture and develop optimism as a valued trait in the workforce. For example, previous research suggests that managers can enhance optimism through individualized support (Rich 1999). Other researchers recommend cognitive training as an effective method for nurturing optimism in boundary-spanning employees. Cognitive training methods seek to change the automatic internal voice of individuals into positively focused thought processes. Once the optimism seed has been planted, it can spread through the use of emotional contagion, where individuals are likely to automatically mimic the optimistic attitudes and behaviors of their colleagues (Adidam and Srivastava 2001).

Recruitment and selection based in part on the optimism trait, compounded with the strategic implementation of training and development practices to enhance the trait of optimism, result in a workforce with an internal characteristic that assists in dealing with the role stressors commonly experienced by boundary spanners. An organization with optimistic employees that also focuses on role stressors when incorporating job design characteristics will provide its boundary-spanning employees with both internal and external mechanisms for coping with role stressors. This dual approach to coping with

role stressors should provide the organization with a pool of boundary-spanning employees who can effectively manage stressors typically associated with their positions.

Boundary-spanning employees with high levels of optimism will experience less felt stress and increased job satisfaction and performance. This relationship implies money-saving opportunities for firms that foster a dual approach to coping with role stressors. These include lower employee turnover and consequently, lower costs for training and recruitment. Additionally, higher levels of job performance lead to greater production within the firm and greater customer satisfaction and retention. Finally, by being able to adjust to stressors, optimistic employees are likely to experience better psychological and physical health. With the growing concern of organizational health costs, strategies such as the dual approach to coping should result in fewer insurance claims, reduced utilization of health insurance, and therefore, lower insurance premiums for the organization.

Another implication related to the finding that optimists respond proactively to stressors is that management should strive for transparency whenever possible. Boundary-spanning employees should be provided a clear job description that details the potential stressors they may encounter. In addition, any upcoming organizational changes that may induce stressors should be communicated to employees in a timely manner. Being straightforward and providing information to employees in advance will enable optimists to contemplate and respond proactively to the stressor, which in turn, will minimize the adverse effects of the stressor.

In addition to vertical communication, the organization should encourage more horizontal communication between boundary-spanning employees. Proactive coping requires the accumulation of resources and skills that are not aimed at a particular stressor but stressors in general (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997). Both Aspinwall and Taylor (1997) and Schwarzer (2000) identify social bonds as important resources needed for coping proactively with stressors, and these bonds can be fostered through horizontal communication. Although optimists tend to have greater social support structures than pessimists, horizontal communication may enable them to expand their support structure even further and provide additional options for managing stressors. Moreover, horizontal communication may enable employees who do not exhibit a high level of optimism to cope more effectively due to the nurtured social support structure. As noted by Chang (1998, p. 1116), a first step to working with pessimists is "to help them see that they have more options available than believed" for managing a

stressful situation. Finally, horizontal communication may enable employees to acquire new skills or refine existing skills (e.g., organizational and planning skills) needed to respond proactively (Aspinwall and Taylor 1997) through their interactions with one another.

Limitations and Future Research

Limitations

Limitations potentially associated with this research should be acknowledged. This research employs a single-industry sample drawn from one organization. Additional research is needed to assess the generalizability of the results to other industries and contexts. Common method bias is another potential limitation, as the independent and dependent variables were collected from the same source. The results of our post hoc testing for common method bias suggest it is not a problem (Podsakoff and Organ 1986). Specifically, principal components analysis of the data identified eight factors with eigenvalues over 1.0, which accounted for approximately 65% of the variance. Our factor analytic results also indicated that one factor did not account for the majority of the variance in the data (only about 25%) and a general factor did not emerge in the unrotated factor structure. Nonetheless, future researchers should collect data from multiple sources to minimize the potential for common method bias.

Finally, this research employs global measures of role ambiguity and role conflict (Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman 1970). Additional insight may be gleaned by employing multifaceted measures of these constructs. For example, Singh and Rhoads (1991) have identified seven facets of role ambiguity. It seems plausible that optimism may enable boundary spanners to cope more effectively with some but not all facets of role ambiguity. Future research might consider investigating the effectiveness of optimism with regard to each of the individual facets of role ambiguity previously identified by Singh and Rhoads (1991).

Future Research

Our results highlight additional areas for future research. More research is required to tease out the specific coping mechanisms optimists are using to deal with current stressors as well as stressors perceived to be just over the horizon. Extracting the specific coping mechanisms used by optimists in these different situations offers managers additional skills for training their boundary-spanning personnel. By treating the stressor-outcome relationship as a dynamic process instead of a static event, the

role of optimism and coping may be better understood. Qualitative research in the form of in-depth interviews with optimistic and pessimistic boundary-spanning personnel may provide some insight on the differential coping mechanisms utilized by optimists.³ Additionally, a longitudinal research design (qualitative and/or quantitative in nature) may provide insight on how optimists versus pessimists respond to anticipated stressors at various stages of the stressor.

Furthermore, whereas previous research has focused on job design, managerial support, and other factors external to the employee as role stressor coping mechanisms, our research underscores the potential importance of an internal characteristic that facilitates coping with role stressors in boundary-spanning positions. While we focused specifically on the optimism construct, there are a number of other constructs psychologists have identified that may potentially influence the coping of boundary-spanning employees. For example, the effectiveness of constructs such as locus of control (e.g., Allen, Weeks, and Moffitt 2005) and self-efficacy (e.g., Brown, Jones, and Leigh 2005) with regard to coping with role stressors might be considered by future researchers.

Researchers have also identified a number of character strengths and virtues that might be considered with regard to their potential for allowing boundary spanners to cope effectively with role stressors (Peterson and Seligman 2004). Character strengths of interest might include creativity, persistence, social intelligence, and citizenship, among others. Investigating the relationships between these strengths and a boundary-spanning employee's ability to cope effectively with role stressors will provide additional breadth and depth to our understanding of these phenomena.

Notes

1. It should be noted that appraisals, coping, and support structure might be interrelated in their effects on adjustment. Appraisals, for example, are related significantly to the coping strategy employed (Chang 1998), which is consistent with Lazarus and Folkman's (1984) stress and coping model of adjustment.

2. Yet another competing model is optimism as a moderator of the role stressor-outcome relationship. We conducted the necessary analyses to examine this model; however, the results did not show any evidence of optimism as a moderator.

3. We thank the editor for this suggestion.

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